

CHAPTER 8

Experiments, Political Elites, and Political Institutions*

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Abstract

The use of experiments to study the behavior of political elites in institutions has a long history and is once again becoming an active field of research. I review that history, noting that government officials within political institutions frequently use random assignment to test for policy effects and to encourage compliance. Scholars of political institutions have generally been slower than practitioners to embrace the use of experiments, though there has been remarkable growth in experimentation by scholars to study political elites. I summarize the domains in which scholars have most commonly used experiments, commenting on how researchers have seized opportunities to leverage random assignment. I highlight design challenges including limited sample sizes, answering theoretically driven questions while partnering with public officials or others, and the difficulty of conducting replications. I then implore scholars to be bold in using experiments to study political institutions while also being mindful of ethical considerations.

The experimental revolution has remade political science and the social sciences, and increasingly scholars are conducting

experiments with political elites and using experiments to study political institutions. While the use of experiments has been

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revise this chapter. This chapter is dedicated to the memory of Dick Fenno, who was an incredible mentor and scholar who left us in 2020. He taught me the value of scholars carefully and ethically intervening with public officials to learn about political representation and institutions and how to interact and engage with policy practitioners. Rest in peace, Dick Fenno.

more dominant in scholarship on political behavior, there has been expansive growth in the use of experiments and methods of causal inference when studying political institutions. The study of political institutions has been enhanced by the use of field, survey, and laboratory experiments.

I argue that the use of randomization and experiments within political institutions was common even before most political scientists used the method to causally estimate empirical effects. The use of randomization and experiments to study political institutions allows for an understanding of causal relationships in a subfield previously thought of as less amenable to experimentation. I then summarize the areas of research in which scholars have most commonly used experiments to study political institutions, and I note particular contributions in the study of legislatures and political representation. I discuss the benefits and challenges of field experiments, survey experiments, and laboratory experiments to study political institutions. In particular, I discuss three challenges in using experiments to study political elites: (1) limited sample sizes and statistical power; (2) answering theoretically driven questions that are of interest to scholars while partnering with public officials or others in field experiments; and (3) the difficulty of conducting replications of some field experiments in places in which there are few similar institutions.

Finally, I encourage scholars studying political institutions using experimental methods to be bold, but to be careful and ethical, when designing such experiments. Given the potential for sample pool depletion and small sample sizes, scholars should move boldly forward in attempting to incorporate experiments for studying institutions where feasible, but the research should be carefully designed with consideration of ethics. Box 8.1 displays the key takeaway points of this chapter for those interested in the use of experiments to study political institutions. I conclude by arguing that experiments are one important method for studying political institutions.

Box 8.1: A guide for scholars using experiments to study political institutions.

- (1) Be mindful of lower statistical power in experimental studies of institutions.
- (2) Partner with external nonprofit or political groups to enhance experiments on institutions.
- (3) Replicate studies. When precise replications are not feasible, pair field experimental evidence with laboratory or survey experimental evidence or pair experimental evidence with observational and descriptive evidence.
- (4) Be bold, but be careful and ethical; conduct experiments on theoretically meaningful questions. Given the paucity of political institutions where experiments are feasible, choose your questions wisely.

8.1 Randomization and Political Institutions: Together for Longer than You Realize

Political institutions are defined as the formal rules, procedures, and organizations – such as legislatures, courts, executive institutions, commissions, and election rules – in which individual or collective behavior occurs or is constrained. Often, though not always, scholars of political institutions examine the decisions and behaviors of political elites within these institutions.

The study of political institutions and experiments have been linked to one another for much longer than most scholars of political science realize. In the discipline of political science, the rise of survey and field experiments is attributed to scholars of individual political behavior (Gerber and Green 2014; Iyengar and Kinder 1987; Robison et al. 2018), which typically examines individual actions and opinions that voters or citizens take. For instance, Gerber and

Green (2000) is often considered the first contemporary field experimental article examining the effect of get-out-the-vote (GOTV) contacts on voter mobilization (Larimer 2018; also see Eldersveld 1956; Gosnell 1927). Chong and Druckman (2007) and others have used survey experiments to understand how framing affects the attitudes of regular people. Following these articles, the amount of behavior research utilizing experiments has increased (Robison et al. 2018). During this surge in the use of experiments to study the behavior and attitudes of the mass public, most scholars of political institutions, in contrast, did not initially adopt experimental methods. Theorists used formal models to specify arguments about political institutions, often leading to comparative static predictions about changes in elite behavior under different institutional arrangements. Empiricists used observational data to answer questions and test theoretical predictions about political institutions, representation, and elites.²

While scholars of political institutions were not as quick to adopt this method nor to embrace causality, practitioners within political institutions used experiments and randomization well before the experimental revolution in political behavior commenced in the 2000s. As Grose and Wood (forthcoming) argue, political institutions themselves have utilized randomization more and earlier than have most scholars of political elites. There are numerous instances of randomization by public officials to distribute limited resources, to test for policy effects, or to carry out random government audits where there are not funds for full audits.

For instance, one of the first known instances of a field experiment on members of the US Congress occurred in the 1970s (Eber 2005; Wood and Grose 2019, forthcoming). This experiment was not conducted by a political scientist, but instead was carried out by an auditor at the newly created Federal Election Commission (FEC). As a

new method of enforcing campaign finance law, the FEC randomly assigned about 10% of Members of Congress to be audited for compliance with the law. Wood and Grose (forthcoming), examining this natural experiment, find that the random assignment of legislators into audits caused legislators to lose more general election votes than their control group colleagues, yet they find that audited legislators went home to their districts no more frequently than those in the control group.

Other instances of randomization conducted by government institutions include the Vietnam draft lottery (Erikson and Stoker 2011); allocation of US congressional offices to new members (Rogowski and Sinclair 2017); allocations of seating of legislators in the Icelandic parliament (Darmofal et al. 2019; Jo and Lowe 2019); random audits of lobbying disclosures by the US Government Accountability Office (Wood and Grose 2019); random draws for which Members of Parliament can submit private bills (Williams and Indridason 2018); lotteries to make committee assignments to legislators (Broockman and Butler 2015; Cirone and Coppenolle 2019; Titunik 2016; Titunik and Feher 2018); and the US state of Georgia randomly distributing land shamefully taken from indigenous people to white men (Hall et al. 2019; Weiman 1991). At many levels of courts, there is often random assignment of judges to cases (Hall 2009, 2010; Kastellec 2011; Levy 2017; Sunstein et al. 2006). Scholars have only recently leveraged these randomized experiments where the randomization has been conducted by political institutions.

Of course, these are not the only instances where public officials have been subject to government randomization, nor where political elites or public officials used random experiments to evaluate policy or for other reasons. However, I note these examples as public officials have been comfortable with the use of randomization and natural experiments even when scholars of political elites have been slower to adopt this method. For decades, many agencies have conducted randomization as part of their institutional

² Though as I note later in this chapter, there were a small number of public choice and institutions scholars conducting laboratory experiments.

procedures or written randomization and policy evaluation into their laws. Also, this randomization by and of public officials in government even precedes the rise of the widespread contemporary use of field and survey experiments to study the mass public (Chong and Druckman 2007; De Rooij et al. 2009) and the adoption of field and survey experimental techniques to study political elites and institutions (Butler 2019; Grose 2014) by social science scholars in the academy.

Given this history of government agencies, political institutions, and political elites using experimentation in the field, it is not surprising that political scientists have also eventually turned to this method to study political institutions and political elites. The scholarly perception that experiments and the study of political institutions are dominant only in the political behavior subfield is wrong. It also suggests that there is room for theoretical and observational work on institutions, but also for continued growth in the use of experiments to study political institutions and political elites. Indeed, I anticipate more multi-method approaches that will utilize experiments while also bringing other nonexperimental data to the research question (e.g., Kriner and Schickler 2014, 2017; Wood and Grose forthcoming). Some of the best work on the study of political institutions – including studies of the US Congress, legislatures, the executive branch, the bureaucracy, public administration, and the courts – uses both experimental methods paired with descriptive data, as not all institutions are amenable to field, survey, or laboratory randomization.

8.2 The Use of Experiments by Scholars to Study Political Institutions and Elites

The scholarly study of political institutions has traditionally been within the rational choice approach, and the earliest laboratory experiments on political institutions used this approach (Fiorina and Plott 1978; Riker 1967; Riker and Zavoina 1970). Excepting this early work utilizing laboratory

experiments, until recently, much empirical scholarship of political institutions has typically relied upon observational data for analysis. This tradition has emphasized that theoretical implications are derived from precise models of institutions and individual behavior. Critiques of this tradition have often come from scholars who advocate for experimental work. As a result, many institutions scholars have mistakenly viewed experiments as not being part of the traditions of the subfield, even though the disciplinary leaders of rational choice and political institutions utilized experimental methods to test their predictions (e.g., Riker 1967 is, to my knowledge, one of the earliest experiments published in the *American Political Science Review*, though preceded by Eldersveld 1956 and Laponce 1966).

A group of scholars of political institutions and elites has emerged to show that experiments are compatible with the study of political institutions and elites. Experiments can be designed that test the theoretical predictions of models of political institutions. Many of the first experiments to study political institutions were conducted in the laboratory. In these experiments, laboratory participants – often convenience samples of students – make choices under randomly assigned institutional arrangements (e.g., Eckel et al. 2010; Enemark et al. 2014; Kanthak and Woon 2015; Morton and Williams 2010; Palfrey 2009). These experiments have internal validity and often test predictions of formal models of strategic behavior in institutions. Other work has used actual treatments designed by legislators and other political elites and randomly assigned them to assess public opinion (e.g., Cover and Brumberg 1982)

Around the late 2000s, a small body of work began to emerge in the area of legislative representation and decision-making in the USA that utilized field experiments. The first field experimental study in a legislature was Bergan (2009), who conducted a field experiment of grassroots lobbying. The experiment was conducted in 2006 in New Hampshire, and a treatment group of legislators were randomly assigned

to receive contact from regular citizens on policies before the floor of the lower house. The article reports mostly null effects of the randomized citizen contacts to legislators, though in one instance there is a sizable and statistically meaningful effect of citizen contact on roll-call voting by legislators.

The first field experiment where members of the US Congress were the subjects was conducted in 2007 with US senators (Grose et al. 2015). This article asks how and why legislators explain their roll-call positions and argues that legislators are likely to offer compensating and reinforcing information to constituents in order to explain their votes (Fenno 1978; Mayhew 1974). These explanations are particularly important when the legislator does not vote in the direction that the constituent wished. An experiment was conducted on US senators where half were initially randomly assigned to receive a position from a constituent favoring immigration reform and the other half were assigned to receive a constituent position against immigration reform. This issue had been subject to cloture votes in this session, providing a public roll-call position for senators that could be compared to their explanations offered to constituents. Actual constituent confederates were used to avoid deception, and a within-subjects design was employed so that all senators received both the pro and the con letters from constituents in two waves. Results showed that Members of Congress were honest and consistent in reporting how they voted to constituent supporters or opponents, but that they explained their votes quite differently when constituents favored immigration reforms in contrast to those constituents who expressed anti-immigration opinions. Additional results showed that these legislator explanations were effective at convincing regular citizens to vote for and support the legislator.

Other early and important field experiments on US state legislatures were conducted in 2008 by Butler and Nickerson (2011) and Butler and Broockman (2011). In Butler and Nickerson (2011), state legislators in one state were randomly assigned to learn constituency opinion about an issue.

Those legislators randomly assigned to this information treatment were more likely to follow constituency opinion when voting. Butler and Broockman (2011) is the first audit study of legislators where the race of constituents was randomly varied. Results suggest that US state legislators are more responsive to a randomly assigned White constituent than to a randomly assigned African American constituent. Legislators were biased against African American constituents, even though this bias should be reduced or removed due to legislators' electoral incentives.

One of the cleverest field experiments with US House members is Kalla and Broockman (2016). Conducted in 2013 in partnership with an advocacy organization, the authors examined whether being a donor causes more access to elected officials for the donor than regular citizens. The advocacy group randomly assigned whether a donor or non-donor contacted the elected officials. Elected officials were much more likely to meet with donor constituents than with non-donor constituents, causally demonstrating that money can buy access to elected officials.

After these early studies, the use of experiments grew in the study of political representation and elites. Audit studies randomly assigned race, ethnicity, gender, immigration status, religion, and other factors to assess whether legislators were differentially responsive to constituents (e.g., Broockman 2014; Bussell 2019; Butler 2014; Gell-Redman et al. 2018; Kalla et al. 2018; Lajevardi 2018; Mendez and Grose 2018). These studies generally showed that legislators in the USA were much less likely to respond to racial and ethnic minorities than to Whites (Costa 2017), and to constituents who lacked immigration status (Dahl 2019; Mendez 2015). Audit studies also revealed important gender differences, with women legislators responding more (Thomsen and Sanders 2019), even when there were no responsiveness differences by gender of constituents. Most of these audit studies were initially conducted in the USA or Europe, but they have expanded to a number of global contexts with political elites. For

instance, in India, legislators have been found not to discriminate on religion and to offer few but meaningful responses to constituents (Vaishnav et al. 2019).

Bureaucrats and other US public officials also have been found to be less responsive to people of color than to Whites (Coppock 2019; White et al. 2015); slightly less responsive to out-partisans (Porter and Rogowski 2018); surprisingly responsive to LGB people (Lowande and Proctor 2019); and equally responsive to high- and low-social status individuals (Lagunes and Pocasangre 2019). In contrast to what one might hope, these studies suggest that legislators are not equally responsive to constituents, despite electoral incentives to be so. For more on audit studies, see Chapter 3 in this volume; also see Chapter 27 on experiments on street-level bureaucrats.

Subsequent to these early legislator field experiments, research utilizing survey experiments where national, state, and local public officials are asked about their attitudes toward policy and politics are also now more common. Naurin and Ohberg (2019) find that public officials in Sweden are amenable to be subjects of experiments, but are also not particularly enthused to be subjects of study. In general, there is reticence for many elected officials, especially in national legislatures, to sit for survey experiments or to partner with scholars. For this reason, survey experiments with subnational elected officials and with subnational bureaucrats are promising (e.g., Anderson et al. 2016; Avellaneda 2013; Druckman and Valdes 2019; Grose and Peterson 2020; Nielsen and Moynihan 2017; Sheffer et al. 2018).

When scholars seek to examine how institutions shape or constrain the attitudes of elected officials, survey experiments of local and subnational public officials are particularly useful. Officials' attitudes can be measured pre- and post-treatment by scholars, and randomized treatments can present institutional and policy scenarios that officials face when governing. For instance, these above-referenced survey experiments have found that elected officials' attitudes can change when their institutional rules

or private preferences are considered (e.g., Anderson et al. 2016; Druckman and Valdes 2019). Other scholars have found that framing leads elected officials to change their attitudes (Sheffer et al. 2018). This framing effect can even cause elected officials to change their beliefs on a pending policy decision, such as when a racial issue is reframed as an economic issue (Grose and Peterson 2020).

8.3 Challenges in Conducting Experiments with Political Elites

There are several unique challenges when conducting experiments on political elites or institutions. I describe three of them below.

8.3.1 Pulling Off Field or Survey Experiments by Partnering with Outside Groups or Public Officials

Conducting field or survey experimental research in coordination with political elites or with external nonprofit or political groups is challenging, yet exciting. For most scholars interested in conducting field or survey experiments, it is a good idea to work with elected officials or outside political groups. By embedding experiments within the work of outside organizations – or working with a public official or agency who delivers a treatment – the scholarship has high external validity. It is also ethically ideal to embed experiments within existing political and governmental institutions, instead of having scholars lead experiments that are not realistic and that may interfere with the day-to-day work of those in institutions. It is generally preferable to conduct experiments with political groups and practitioners when studying political institutions.

To be done well, scholars must possess a deep understanding of the institutions and people they study, or develop and possess connections with public officials and outside organizations (see Chapter 11 in this volume and Levine 2020). Groups are less willing to partner with scholars who do not share their interests in the real world of policy and politics; or in

contexts in which there is not trust between scholar and organization. Outside groups often want to harness the power of the gold standard of experimentation in order to evaluate public policy, evaluate their employees, or evaluate the effectiveness of their tactics with elected officials. Scholars must understand the incentives of elected and public officials and/or outside groups in order to successfully partner with them. When scholarly incentives for knowledge generation and practitioner incentives for learning what works in their organization align, field experiments to understand and learn more about political institutions and political elites are much easier to implement. By partnering with outside organizations or practitioners, scholars can address questions – particularly using field experiments – that would not otherwise be possible in randomized interventions conducted only by scholars. For example, scholars would not want to conduct a lobbying experiment of elected officials without partnering with an external organization for ethical and legal reasons. However, an interest group who conducts a lobbying campaign could embed a randomized experiment in the advocacy work in which they regularly engage. Scholars seeking to conduct such experiments should work closely to form relationships and seek feedback from political elites and real-world political groups before conducting a field or survey experiment. This qualitative knowledge and feedback of what political elites hope to learn from experiments can help inform theoretically driven experiments in political science that are feasible (see Chapter 20 in this volume on multi-method approaches).

Examples abound of such experiments with elites. While the scholarship utilizing experiments often does not detail the ways in which the experiment came about, it would behoove scholars to explain more about why the outside group agreed to partner to conduct the experiment. For instance, one experiment by Zelizer (2019) involved a partnership with legislators in order to assess cue-taking by legislators and whether this cue-taking was endogenous.

In this experiment, the scholar partnered with US state legislators in one state to conduct the experiment. The legislators, presumably, were interested in learning what techniques worked to get their bills passed. Zelizer (2019) embedded a cue-taking experiment within a legislature and found that legislators take cues from their colleagues in their self-selected, endogenous networks. This work provides experimental evidence similar to Kingdon's (1973) classic descriptive argument (see also Zelizer 2018).

In my own experience, one can conduct scholarly led randomized interventions with public officials as subjects and also field experimental partnerships with public officials and organizations. With the exception of audit studies, where constituents are randomly assigned to contact legislators or other elected officials, I have found partnership experiments to be the most challenging yet also the most externally valid and novel. I would recommend this latter approach to most scholars hoping to study political institutions, especially with field experimentation. In one instance, a lobbyist and interest group randomly assigned the types of visits with legislative staff in order to assess the lobbyist's effectiveness (Grose et al. forthcoming). This aligned with the outside actors' incentives, and also allowed for us to test a theoretical question about direct lobbying and its effect on legislator position-taking. The outside lobbying firm and interest group was interested in learning more about their tactics, and was also interested in assisting with scholarship. In the article, we argue and find that social lobbying, defined as meetings between lobbyists and public officials that take place in social spaces such as restaurants and coffee shops, are more likely to yield legislative support for interest group-preferred policy. Lobbyist meetings randomly assigned to be held in a social space with legislators yielded more legislative support than meetings held in a legislative office or a control group in which no direct lobbying occurred.

In another instance, I have partnered with an institute and a former elected legislator to examine the policy diffusion of some state

policies to elected officials in other states (Grose 2019). By partnering with a former elected official, the response rate of elected officials in the survey was likely higher than had I been the only person associated with the survey, and the former legislator's participation made the treatment embedded in the survey more realistic as it came from a former legislator as opposed to just a scholar of political science.

In the study, a survey was disseminated to state legislators across the country who are members of an environmental legislative caucus. This caucus includes members who care about environmental policy and where legislators have chosen to participate. The survey randomly assigned some members of this cross-state environmental policy caucus into a treatment group to receive access to a web portal of summaries and the texts of policies passed in a number of states. The control group did not receive these bills from other states. Then, all state legislators were asked to evaluate and answer questions about their new ideas for state policies on the environment. Results showed that legislators exposed to new policy ideas were more likely to express interest in adopting those policies and to point to those states as sources for where they develop legislation relative to the control group. In addition, the behavioral outcomes of the legislators in the survey were able to be included because of the participation of the former elected official, and we were able to test whether legislators sought help from this former legislator in drafting legislation they learned about and that diffused from other states. These partnerships yield better research, increase external validity, and reduce deception to subjects.

One particularly successful partnership was work on encouraging women to run for party offices. Karpowitz et al. (2017) partnered with the Utah Republican party to conduct an encouragement experiment. Their theory argued that both supply and demand explain the paucity of women running for office, and this was tested by varying supply-and-demand messages to rank-and-file delegates of the party. The state

party delivered these messages in randomly assigned precincts and not in others. Here, the political elites were party delegates, and the treatment was also delivered by the party delegates. The outcome was the decision to run for higher-level party positions. The authors find that party leaders' efforts to increase supply by having more women run and efforts to increase demand for more women officeholders increase the choice of women to run for and hold these elected party positions.

To pull off such a partnership, scholars must be willing to branch out into the real world of politics. In some instances, a field experimental idea must be pitched to the outside organization or public officials. Scholars and outside groups benefit from forming agreements and memos of understanding prior to the launching of the experiment, in addition to the usual preregistration of the study and institutional review board submissions. Scholars also need to be willing to pivot from their initial ideas and move toward research ideas that emerge in discussions with practitioners and outside organizations. This is not quite a methodological challenge, but is a theory-to-empirics challenge. Theory should drive the research questions in our work, and thus a well-developed field experiment that connects directly to its theoretical predictions is the ideal. In practice, though, scholars may need to approach several outside groups before there is one willing to conduct the theoretically relevant experiment as a partner. Scholars should not conduct experiments that are theoretically irrelevant or that do not comport with their theoretical predictions. However, scholars must have some flexibility when partnering with outside groups to conduct experiments. Many outside organizations and practitioners are enthusiastic to use experimentation to learn what is effective, and these experiments are successful for all parties when policy evaluations of interest to the practitioners align with the ability to test the theoretical implications of interest to social scientists.

In addition, another limitation to all experiments, but perhaps particularly an issue

with institutions, is that there are strategic and repeated interactions between public officials. Thus, a one-shot experiment may not allow for tests of theories based on repeated interactions with public officials or with officials and outside interest groups. Legislators engage in repeated interactions with one another in voting; lobbyists and interest groups engage in years of developing relationships with elected officials; and bureaucrats engage with one another and other public officials in repeated interactions. Thus, even when scholars are able to partner with organizations, there are constraints on what can be studied. Because people within political institutions communicate a lot with one another, there could be a concern over stable unit treatment value assumption (SUTVA) violations in these types of studies of institutions (if those in the treatment group communicate the treatment to those in the control group; see Zelizer 2019 and Chapter 16 in this volume on SUTVA). This is not always going to be a problem in some studies of institutions, but scholars should consider ways to assess whether communications between subjects could lead to SUTVA violations.

8.3.2 Sample Size, Statistical Power, and Experiments with Political Elites in Institutions

One common political institution in which experiments have been used to study political elites is in legislatures. Here, the subjects are often legislators themselves, or the staff of legislators. Most national legislatures across the world range from about 50–700 members. In Germany, the parliament's lower house has 709 members and the upper house has 69 members. In Japan, the legislature has 465 members in the lower house and 242 members in the upper house, while in Argentina, the lower house has only 257 members and the upper house has 72 members.

In the USA, scholars have conducted field experiments in small-to-medium-sized legislatures, such as on the US Senate (Grose et al. 2015) and with US House members

as subjects (Kalla and Broockman 2015). In the US states, the largest state legislature is New Hampshire's lower house with 400 members, and this chamber has been subject to multiple field experiments as a result (e.g., Bergan 2009). Most US state legislatures total about 100–200 legislators, and sometimes fewer than 100 legislators. Other US state legislatures with fewer legislators have also been settings for field experiments of lobbying (Grose et al. 2019) and information (Butler and Nickerson 2011; Zelizer 2018).

In studying any legislature, sample size is obviously an issue. Statistical power is thus a concern, and it is an even greater concern in studies involving multiple treatment conditions. Even though there is a move in the behavior literature toward massively scaled GOTV field experiments with very large samples, this is simply not feasible in almost all work where legislators or other actors embedded within political institutions are subjects. The statistical evidence offered in research on political institutions will more often than not have larger standard errors than those that are found in studies based on large-scale voter mobilization field experiments due to sample size. Another strategy is to increase sample size by studying political institutions such as bureaucracies that have larger potential subject pools (e.g., Andersen and Moynihan 2016).

Because of low statistical power, scholars should focus on the magnitude of the effect and also take care in interpreting the statistical test (Gill 1999). Scholars must recognize this limitation of statistical power, but should nevertheless continue to study political institutions given the scholarly import of the research questions. In designing experiments with political elites, the number of randomized conditions often needs to be lower given the small sample sizes.

Given small sample sizes, scholars should seek meaningful, fairly infrequent, and bold interventions. Scholars of political institutions cannot afford to engage in small interventions or optimizations that may be allowable in the literature on mass behavior where there are nearly unlimited subject pools in vast numbers.

When studying political institutions, scholars should not waste a field experimental or survey experimental intervention answering a relatively minor theoretical or substantive question. When interventions are important and impactful, the concerns regarding small sample sizes may be lessened. Scholars must also carefully consider the impacts of their interventions and take great care in their design, given these limited subject pools and small sample sizes.

To create meaningful interventions, as mentioned above, working with outside groups in the nonprofit or political realms can assist the experimenter. Not only is the experiment more externally valid, but these groups that scholars partner with can also generate the interventions. Realistic interventions are often meaningful interventions. When interventions are meaningful, the experiment is worth doing, even with a small sample size.

8.3.3 Replication versus Additional Evidence in the Experimental Study of Political Elites

Replication is critically important in the study of political behavior and elites, and scholars studying political institutions – especially given small sample sizes – should seek to engage in replications (see Chapter 19 in this volume). The ideal replication strategy is to conduct multiple experiments on different subject populations. This may be an initial field experiment conducted in partnership with an organization and a replication conducted by the scholar.

However, it will not always be possible to conduct an exact replication across multiple political institutions. Scholars who have partnered with an organization, for instance, to conduct a field experiment may be unable to persuade the same organization to conduct a second replication experiment in a different context. Advocacy groups may be based in one legislature and do not always have the appetite or resources to conduct replications in another legislature. In some instances, conducting multiple experiments in the same legislature with the same treatment and control

conditions will not be feasible because the legislators will learn over time and become aware that they are being experimented upon in the replications.

For experimental studies of political institutions such as legislatures, when precise replications are not feasible, scholars should bring additional and multiple forms of evidence to bear on the theoretical question. In contrast to scholars of political institutions, experimentalists who focus on regular people as subjects can simply draw another survey sample to conduct a replication with identical survey questions asked across multiple experiments. Another GOTV study replication can be conducted as the number of voter subjects will not be depleted. However, in small legislatures, political institutions, and organizations, it may not be feasible to conduct multiple replications.

Scholars of political institutions may need to resort to a field experiment supplemented with survey experimental evidence that addresses the same research question – even if the survey experiment is not a precise replication of the field experiment. Alternatively, a field experiment embedded in an institution could be paired with a replication in the laboratory where lab subjects are in institutional arrangements that mirror or reflect the interventions in the field institutional setting. In addition, observational or nonexperimental survey data that parallel outcomes from a field or survey experiment provide additional descriptive evidence when the scholar is unable to conduct an experimental replication, or a survey experiment with political elites could be paired with a similar survey experiment of regular citizens.

8.4 Experiments with Political Institutions: Be Bold, but Be Careful and Ethical

Moving the discipline forward requires scholars consider ways to incorporate randomized experimentation into our study of political institutions. Yet there still seems

to be reticence among some scholars of institutions who tend to prefer not to conduct experiments. Criticisms of experimental interventions from institutions scholars exist, and they are often whispered at conferences and in professional associations. Typically, one concern is that experimental interventions burden the time of political elites. I agree that scholars of institutions must carefully consider the ethics of experiments and interventions (whether these interventions are randomized or not; see Grose 2015). However, scholars should conduct bold and meaningful experiments in political institutions, as most experimental interventions with political elites have been relatively minimal when compared to scholars using nonexperimental methodological approaches.

For instance, most extant research using field experiments to study political institutions and elites engages in very light and minimal interventions, contrary to the impression among some institutions scholars. The audit studies of legislators and other elected officials are typically short emails to which the officials can choose to respond in a matter of seconds. Contrast these minimal interventions to interventions of other political institutions scholars with observational approaches, which are typically much bolder in terms of the time and other commitments required from public officials. Scholars have used Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) laws to request information and data, even if the FOIA requests have been particularly time-intensive or burdensome. Classic and important research conducted long surveys of the membership of the US Congress (Miller and Stokes 1963) or allowed for participant observation of US House members for hours or days at a time (Fenno 1978). This nonexperimental research placed enormous time burdens on public officials – and also was some of the most consequential research on political institutions for generations.

In fact, just as critics of experiments with institutions today lament the time burdens to public officials, so did scholars of an earlier era lament the time burdens of participant

observation, interviews, and surveys. Dexter (1964), writing in *Public Opinion Quarterly*, went so far as to say there were too many PhD students nonexperimentally intervening with federal public officials in the 1950s and 1960s. Dexter lamented that these PhD students – such as a young Dick Fenno – were wasting the time and “good will of important people” by conducting interviews and surveys of federal elected officials.

These criticisms of observational interventions decades ago mirror some of those criticisms of experimental interventions with political elites heard by some contemporary scholars of institutions. However, in contrast, most experimental interventions with political elites conducted solely by scholars have been fairly minimal in terms of time burdens to the elected officials relative to much of the classic work in the study of political institutions and representation. When one is an expert who studies institutions, there will be substantial time commitments and interventions with political elites. As a result, it is extremely important for experimentalists to value and respect their ethical obligations when interacting with elected officials so as to allow for continued experimental and nonexperimental interventions with these political elites by future scholars.

But given that most of the current experimental scholarship on political elites has focused mostly on one-time, small email interventions with elected officials via audits, I would recommend that experimental scholars of institutions think bigger, but think ethically and carefully. In future research, bolder interventions that allow for electoral or political institutions to be randomly varied could be a goal of scholars, and I anticipate other clever and impactful randomized experiments with political elites. There has always been an appetite for political institutions to conduct randomization within their own institutions, and thus scholars can also work with these institutions to conduct significant and new research. Just as Miller and Stokes (1963) and Fenno (1978) boldly intervened with legislators nonrandomly in an earlier scholarly generation, the

current vanguard of scholarship can engage in meaningful experimental interventions with public officials within political institutions.

The research must be carefully designed so as to be ethical and respectful to political elites. Given the possibilities of pool depletion and small samples, the theoretical merit of the studies must be very high for the scholar to engage in randomized experiments with political elites. Scholars should not engage in purely scholarly led interventions that have the potential to put any elected official at higher-than-minimal risk. For the boldest interventions, scholars should have outside groups conduct interventions. An advocacy organization who planned on lobbying elected officials nonrandomly – a significant and bold intervention – will do so whether the lobbying is randomized or not. Thus, having the group randomize the intervention of lobbying is new and impactful scholarship, but it is also ethically acceptable, as elected officials were already receiving the interventions from the outside group. This type of advocacy experiment would not be a good idea for a solely scholarly led intervention, but would be ideal for an outside group to partner with a scholar to conduct. It is essential that scholars carefully consider and review the ethics of experiments with political elites, but also to think creatively on how new experiments can be conducted in the field, the lab, and with surveys to improve our understanding of political institutions. By intervening with and observing directly our elected officials and political institutions, we learn.

To summarize, there are significant challenges – but also exciting and theoretically important opportunities for scholars interested in experiments in the study of political institutions. The frontier of experimental interventions with political elites and with political institutions should be bold and ethical. The best strategy for conducting such bold and ethical experimental research may be to partner with external groups who conduct interventions that are randomized.

8.5 Conclusion

The rise of experiments in political science in the 2000s is clear from a perusal of the discipline's top journals (Robison et al. 2018). The study of political institutions and political elites has also seen a rise in experimental methods over time, but the number of experiments – especially field experiments – is relatively small in the study of institutions. Good, theoretically driven work that empirically leverages field, survey, or laboratory experiments is critical to enhance our understanding of political institutions. The method should not drive the question, but the theory and the question should drive the empirical analysis. We have had decades of important questions about political polarization, parties in legislatures, and many other topics answered with observational data, and important work in this vein will continue. There are also now many unanswered questions that can be addressed with field experimental and other experimental methods, and existing questions that have not been examined with experimental or causal methods. Even more scholarship on political institutions should pair experimental methods with observational methods. There is much scholarship that remains to be done utilizing experimental methods to help us understand the behavior of political elites and political institutions. The gold standard of experiments to assess causality is an emergent method in the study of political elites and institutions.

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